

I was a little tense about the meeting. I had heard that Harshad was quite voluble, the exact opposite of somebody like me who had trouble making conversation. I worried my reticence would make me appear unimpressive to Harshad.

Sharma and I went together to the Grasshopper. We were ten minutes late. Harshad was already there with seven others, all of them stock market friends. I knew all of them by name, and I guess they too were aware of my existence. As usual, Sharma was to the point while introducing me.

He placed his hand on my shoulder and said to Harshad, 'This is Lalchand, better known as Lala.'

I managed to mutter a feeble hello to Harshad, but was so awestruck that I involuntarily bowed while greeting him.

Harshad eyed me for a couple of seconds, and I could sense that he was sizing me up.

'I am Harshad, how do you do, Lala?' he responded with a warm smile.

I was a bit taken aback at the humility with which he introduced himself. Of course I knew his name. But then, that was part of Harshad's charm, and as I would learn later, he had a knack of putting people at ease in his company.

'Arre Sharma, when you mentioned a jobber who loved to finger those robbers, I certainly did not imagine a college kid,' Harshad said, and turned towards me. 'You seem to have got the hang of the game early on; that's important if you are to survive the first couple of years, always the toughest. Reminds me of my initial days in the ring.'

I would be lying if I said the remarks did not swell my head. And that's exactly the effect Harshad must have intended. But it made me all the more tongue-tied, and I did not know what to say.

But one of Harshad's friends saved me the trouble by butting into the conversation. Being a Friday, there was a fairly long waiting list of diners. From the look of it, I felt we would have to wait for anywhere between half an hour to an hour.

'... that's why I was saying, Harshadbhai, we should have booked in advance. It is going to be a long wait,' the friend, Viren, told Harshad.

'But why take the trouble of booking in advance when you can get a table without much difficulty?' Harshad said.

I wondered if Harshad had thought he would be recognized by the restaurant staff and promptly ushered to a table. He might be well known in